

Privacy is a myth, of course!

This month was another not-so-friendly reminder that where every click, scroll, and swipe becomes part of a vast web of data, privacy has become more of a comforting illusion than a reality. While this has been spoken about a lot, it's two recent incidents that made me re-think – one that affects everyone, the other very personal.

The first, which affects a lot of people, involves Cybernews' report about billions of credentials exposed through a malware. This was probably the biggest data leak known to mankind. So big that if you are on the internet, chances are that your data has already been compromised. For the unversed, over 16 billion login credentials were exposed this month, in what was one of the largest data breaches in history. The data most likely originates from various infostealers.

This type of malware quietly collects sensitive data like login details, financial information and browsing histories from infected devices. This stolen data often lands on the dark web, feeding a massive cybercrime economy. What's scarier is how effortlessly these malware programs sneak into our systems – hidden in legitimate-looking apps or harmless downloads.

This breach makes us question: how secure are we, really? Even with strong passwords, two-factor authentication and antivirus software, our defenses can still be penetrated by determined cybercriminals.

Who is to be blamed? It's difficult to point fingers anymore. Social media platforms, apps and smart devices have turned our lives into a goldmine of information. Platforms like Facebook, Instagram and Snapchat collect everything from our browsing habits to our locations and even our unspoken preferences. They monetise this data through targeted ads and partnerships, often without users fully understanding what they've agreed to.

AI platforms have taken this data collection to the next level. Advanced systems like recommendation engines and generative AI models use massive datasets to personalise services. While this can make our lives easier, it also means that our private conversations,



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preferences and behaviours are analysed and, in some cases, manipulated to drive decisions or influence opinions.

The second incident I spoke about which is more personal was the discovery of a Telegram bot by one of my colleagues that throws anyone's information by feeding in their phone number. This has to be one of the most chilling examples of privacy's decline. These bots can reveal personal details like phone numbers, addresses and even your Aadhaar number with just a phone number.

Operating in legal gray zones, these tools show how far privacy has eroded. While their creators may argue they're simply aggregating existing data, the risks to personal safety and security are undeniable.

It should always be known that our love for convenient tech comes at a hefty cost. Smart assistants like Alexa and Google Home are always listening. Fitness trackers know our health metrics, and GPS-enabled apps track our every move. All this info feeds into servers, which aren't impervious to breaches.

Even the idea of “consent” is blurry in today's tech-driven age. Most of us click “I agree” without reading the terms, inadvertently granting companies the right to store and share our data. Even opting out of certain features doesn't guarantee privacy, as data collection continues under the guise of improving services or “anonymised” data.

Laws like Europe's GDPR and California's CCPA aim to protect user data, but enforcement is inconsistent. Tech companies often find loopholes, prioritising profits over accountability. In countries with weaker regulations, the problem is worse. Data breaches and unethical practices leave users vulnerable. Without a unified global approach, privacy protection is easily bypassed.

From malware breaches to data-hungry AI and invasive bots, the signs are clear: the era of true privacy is over. Still, it's not all doom and gloom. By staying informed, advocating for better practices, and using tools that prioritise security, we can regain some control.

Privacy may feel like a myth today, but it's a myth worth striving to turn back into reality. **d**